

Why do we eat dairy on Shavuot?

1) Torah is Likened to Milk

In The Song of Songs (4:11) Hashem says to the Jewish people, “The sweetness [of Torah] drops from your lips; like honey and milk it lies under your tongue.” Since the Torah is compared to milk, we eat a dairy meal on Shavuot, when the Torah was given.



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2) Milk is Purified – Torah Purifies

Honey is made by the bee, and milk is a byproduct of blood (see Bechorot 6b), and the Torah forbids eating blood.

Thus, both milk and honey originate from a source which is tamei – spiritually unclean – and after the product is developed it is tahor – halachically clean – for human consumption.

Torah is compared to milk and honey because of its power to elevate and purify even one who has fallen into a state of spiritual contamination. Incidentally, some have a custom to also eat honey on Shavuot for the same reasons.



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3) Torah and Humility

The comparison of Torah to milk teaches us that just as milk keeps best in earthenware and spoils quickly in silver or golden utensils, Torah remains with humble people and despises the arrogant.



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4) Reminds of Moshe's Being Saved

Moshe was born on the 7th of Adar. Three months later, his mother put him in a basket and placed him among the reeds at the bank of the river. Batya, the daughter of Pharaoh, found him and he refused to drink the milk of any of the Egyptian women. Consequently, she was forced to hire Yocheved (his mother) to raise him. This incident took place on the 6th of Sivan, the day when years later Moshe would receive the Torah on Mt. Sinai (Sotah 12b). Since he was miraculously reunited with his mother on the 6th of Sivan through milk, a dairy meal is eaten on Shavuot.



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5) Moshe Got Torah Because of Avraham's Hospitality

According to the Midrash Rabbah (Shemot, 28:1), the angels wanted to attack Moshe for coming to take the Torah down to earth. Hashem altered his face to resemble Avraham's and said to them, "Aren't you ashamed to attack the person who was so hospitable to you?"

Avraham served the angels cream, milk, and meat (Bereishit 18:8). To commemorate this meal, which contributed to the Jewish people receiving the Torah on Shavuot, we eat a dairy meal, and a meat meal an hour later.



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6) Milk = 40

The Hebrew word for milk is "chalav" (חלב) having the numerical value of 40. Eating a dairy meal recalls the 40 days Moshe was up in heaven to receive the Torah.



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7) Two Loaves for Dairy and Meat Meals

In the Beit HaMikdash on Shavuot there was a meal-offering that consisted of Two Loaves baked from chadash – the new wheat crop – which was harvested or formed roots at least three days before Pesach (see Vayikra 23:17). Until then all the meal-offerings had to be from the flour of earlier crops, and the Two Loaves made permissible the use of the new crop in the meal-offerings of the Beit Hamikdash. (The Omer-offering of Pesach was of barley and made the use of new crop permissible for individuals see p. 7). For the dairy and meat meals, according to halachah, separate loaves of bread have to be used. Thus, the eating of a dairy meal followed by a meat meal (at least one hour later) necessitates the use of two separate loaves which, in turn, commemorates the Two-Loaf meal-offering offered on Shavuot.



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8) Dairy Meal was More Convenient

Though many people observed Torah precepts before the Torah was actually given, nevertheless, it was permitted to eat meat of a killed animal which was not ritually slaughtered. Once the Torah laws were conveyed, the only meat permissible was that of a ritually slaughtered animal. To have such meat it is necessary to have a chalif – slaughtering knife – that is extremely sharp, and without any imperfection. Preparing a chalif is a tedious and time consuming task. After the animal is slaughtered there are again many halachot concerning its preparation for cooking (e.g. removing non-kosher fats, soaking and salting) which requires much time. Moreover, the actual cooking (in new utensils) also takes much time. Hence, for technical reasons the simplest and most convenient thing was to make the first meal a dairy one. This was the easiest to prepare and least time consuming.

To commemorate the dairy meal which was eaten after the giving of the Torah, we too eat a dairy meal on the festival that commemorates the giving of the Torah.

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9) Commemorates “Seeing the Sounds”

A unique thing about the kashrut status of milk is that it depends on whether a Jew saw the milking. As the Gemara (Avodah Zarah 35b) says that “it is forbidden to drink milk which was milked by a non-Jew when a Jew did not see him milking.”

A unique thing that took place when the Torah was given is that “And all the people could see the sounds” (Shemot 20:15) – they saw that which is audible; i.e. they saw the sounds that emerged from the mouth of Hashem (Rashi).

To commemorate the receiving of the Torah in a visual way, we eat dairy which may be eaten only if a Jew saw the milking.



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10) Limited Meat Consumption Because of Anninut

When a relative for whom one must observe mourning passes away, G-d forbid, the survivor is an onein until the burial, and is forbidden to eat meat. The laws of anninut do not apply to Yom-Tov. Nevertheless, the Jerusalem Talmud, (Chagigah 2:3) says King David passed away on Shavuot and the entire community were onenim, and due to their great agony, shalmei chagigah – festival peace-offerings – were not offered and postponed for the following day.

A reason for reading Megillat Ruth on Shavuot is because King David passed away on this day and his genealogy is delineated in it. Thus, to commemorate that all the people were onenim on that day and they did not eat some of the sacrificial meat normally eaten, we eat dairy. (But, since in reality anninut is not practiced on Yom Tov, and even on the day of David's passing, they offered the obligatory sacrifices such as the daily offering and musafim, and ate the meat, we also eat a meat meal to bring us into a joyous Yom Tov spirit.)

